



IELTS for admission: the score you need and where you can skip it

Verified thresholds at universities in nine destinations, accepted alternatives, and the mistakes that force a retake

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Half the language question is answered by one number: the score your programme asks for. The other half is that many universities let you skip the certificate altogether. Below are checked requirements at the universities we work with.

How the exam works

IELTS has four parts: listening, reading, writing and speaking. Each part and the overall result are scored from 0 to 9 in half-band steps. The certificate is valid for **two years** — the same rule applies to TOEFL and PTE, while Cambridge certificates do not expire.

Admission almost always means the **Academic** module, not General Training. Some universities accept both — Politecnico di Milano and NABA in Italy count General as well. If you are choosing what to sit, sit Academic: it is accepted everywhere.

Thresholds at the universities we work with

Checked on 21.09.2026 against official university pages. Confirm on the programme page before you apply: universities change requirements between intakes.

Destination and university	Bachelor's	Master's and medicine
Türkiye, Istanbul Medipol	IELTS Academic 6.5 or TOEFL iBT 84	same threshold
Türkiye, METU	IELTS not accepted since 24.12.2022 — TOEFL iBT or PTE instead	same
Italy, Bocconi	6.5, with at least 6.0 in every part	—
Italy, Politecnico di Milano	from 5.0 (Academic or General)	from 6.0
Italy, NABA and Marangoni	5.0	5.0
Hungary, IBS	from 6.0	from 6.5
Hungary, Budapest Metropolitan	5.5, certificate optional — an online interview instead	5.5
Hungary, McDaniel	6.5	—
Malaysia, UM	5.5	6.0
Malaysia, Taylor's	5.5	MBBS 6.0
Malaysia, UCSI	5.0	MD 6.0
Malaysia, APU	4.5; 5.0 for IT and finance	5.5; MBA 6.0
North Cyprus, EMU	5.5	medicine 6.0
North Cyprus, CIU and NEU	5.5 or the university's own exam	same
North Cyprus, GAU	5.0; 5.5 on some programmes	5.5
North Cyprus, METU NCC	6.0 or PTE 55	6.0
Cyprus, UNIC	from 6.0	from 6.5
Cyprus, EUC	from 6.5	from 6.5
UAE, Middlesex Dubai	6.0 with at least 5.5 per part (Foundation 5.5)	higher, depends on the programme
UAE, Heriot-Watt Dubai	6.0	6.0

Georgian universities accept IELTS and TOEFL, but each sets its own threshold — we confirm it per programme.

When you do not need the certificate

- **The university's own English exam.** CIU and NEU in North Cyprus, and several Turkish universities, run their own test on campus or online.

- **An online interview.** Budapest Metropolitan in Hungary admits without a certificate on the strength of an interview.
 - **School or a degree taught in English.** Many universities exempt graduates of English-medium schools and programmes. Malaysia also counts Year 11 English at school and the national MUET exam.
 - **A preparatory language year.** If your score falls short, universities in Türkiye, North Cyprus and Malaysia enrol you on an English foundation year and move you to year one once you pass it.
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Alternatives to IELTS

TOEFL iBT is accepted almost everywhere, PTE Academic at most universities, the Duolingo English Test less often (IBS in Hungary takes it from 105), Cambridge B2 First and C1 Advanced frequently and without expiry, MUET in Malaysia.

One warning: **online formats are not universally accepted.** Medipol counts neither IELTS Online nor TOEFL Home Edition — only a test centre sitting. Check this before you pay the exam fee.

Five mistakes that force a retake

- **Sitting General instead of Academic.** For a university that is usually the wrong module.
 - **Hitting the overall score but not the per-part minimum.** Bocconi asks 6.5 with 6.0 in every part, Middlesex 6.0 with 5.5 — the overall band alone will not carry you.
 - **Sitting online where only a test centre counts.**
 - **An expired certificate.** The two years run to the application date, not to the start of the programme.
 - **Sitting too late.** Results arrive within days, but the university needs time to verify them. Leave a month before the application deadline.
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How to prepare in three months

- Take a mock test at the start: it shows which part drags you down, and the plan follows from there.
 - The weak part is usually writing, and what it needs is structure — an introduction, two argued paragraphs, a conclusion — rather than vocabulary.
 - Speaking improves only by speaking: 15 minutes out loud a day beats an hour of theory.
 - In the last month switch to full timed mock tests: the exam runs for nearly three hours, and stamina decides as much as language.
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We will confirm the score you need. Send us your shortlist — we will check the requirement for each programme, work out how long you need to prepare, and tell you where no certificate is needed at all. The first consultation is free. AcademGo office: Warsaw, ul. Złota 7/28.

Tell us your programmes and we will confirm the score you need and when to sit the test

AcademGo — study abroad consultancy. All figures come from official university and government sources; check the year of the price list before you pay.